

Union luck

On September 13, McClellan's troops entered Frederick, recently vacated by the Army of Northern Virginia. McClellan then enjoyed a stroke of luck. A copy of Lee's Special Order 191, circulated to all the Confederate commanders on September 9, was found in a field outside the town and passed to McClellan's staff. It gave full details of the location of Lee's forces. McClellan was exultant, declaring: "Here is a paper with which if I cannot whip Bobbie Lee, I will be willing to go home." On the night of September 13, Union forces moved toward South Mountain. Once through the passes they would be able to attack Lee's army before it could concentrate or escape. While Longstreet marched back from Hagerstown, the Confederate defenses at the mountain passes were lightly held. Fighting raged through September 14. Crampton's Gap fell after hours of resistance by a handful of Confederates faced with 12,000 Union troops, but this was exploited too late. Turner's Gap and Fox's Gap were held by D. H. Hill's division throughout the day. The delay that this imposed on McClellan's army was enough to allow Lee to escape. On September 15, McClellan ordered his troops to retreat to the town of Sharpsburg, between Antietam Creek and the Potomac.

120,000 The number of soldiers that General McClellan estimated Lee had in his army during the Maryland campaign. The actual number of Confederate troops never exceeded around 55,000.

Taking Harpers Ferry

Meanwhile, Jackson was threatening Harpers Ferry. The arsenal was guarded by 11,000 green Union troops under Colonel Dixon Miles. Holding the high ground, the Confederates sited their artillery and attacked at will. Harpers Ferry surrendered on September 15. Jackson seized military stores as well as 11,000 prisoners. Leaving Major General A. P. Hill's men in charge, Jackson joined Lee at Sharpsburg. He arrived on September 16 to find Lee facing McClellan's army across Antietam Creek. All day the opposing artillery batteries had been dueling. Darkness brought the additional rattle of heavy skirmishing up and down the lines, a prelude to impending battle.